to finish it. After all, it was neither a robot story nor a Foundation story, and with few exceptions, every story I had written in the past six years had been either one or the other. I was becoming anxious not to find myself in a Foundation/robot rut.

On May 20, I finally finished it, and took it in to Campbell on the twenty-sixth. It was 7,500 words long, and on May 31, I received a welcome check for $150.

In my conversation with Campbell on the twenty-sixth, however, something rather unusual came up. It came about this way:

In running my chronometric experiments, I put my enzyme solution into the vessel first and then quickly dumped the catechol solution into it. The enzyme reaction starts at once. First, of course, I had to prepare the catechol solution fresh, for it would undergo spontaneous changes that would make the experiment meaningless if it were allowed to stand around too long.

At the beginning of each day, therefore, I would prepare the catechol solution. I would weigh out a fixed quantity of solid catechol, which comes as white, very fluffy, needlelike crystals, and then I would dump it little by little into a beaker of distilled water.

Catechol, as it happens, is very readily soluble, especially when it exists as fluffy crystals that present a large surface to the water. The result is that as soon as the catechol touches the surface of the water it dissolves. It just seems to vanish without ever penetrating the water's skin.

As I watched it one morning 5 I thought idly: What if it dissolves just before it hits the water?

That, I thought at once, might make the basis for a science-fiction story.

But then I thought again. It would not be long now before I would have to write up my research observations in the form of a long and complicated dissertation. That dissertation would have to be written in a convoluted and stylized fashion or it would never pass.

I dreaded that. I had spent nine years now trying to learn to write clearly and well, and now I would have to write a dissertation tur-

5 I did not record, in mv diary, exactly which morning, but it could not have been long before May 26, 1947.